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From the editor-in-chief

At INDIA TODAY, every December is not merely a time to take stock of the year, but to look back on our own years. We began in 1975 and since then have evolved and kept in step with a news environment that always has been frenetic and often most unexpected. Our world has changed enormously in these years, going from India's brutal Emergency in the year we launched our first issue to the global war against terrorism which finds its way to our covers fairly regularly now.

Actually, history is made of many small events but it's the disasters, the catastrophes, the controversies which catch our attention. But the ones that make the headlines are not the only things that change people's lives and the destinies of countries. These less reported events are often quiet revolutions which greatly benefit people and some which cause grief. Let us say that if there have been more than a few villains in our country's public life over INDIA TODAY's timespan, then there have also fortunately been more than a few heroes. Similarly, if there has been great triumph in a year, it can also contain quiet undercurrents of turmoil which find true expression much later.

To mark this 34th anniversary of INDIA TODAY, we decided to go back in time through all our issues, to single out those events that may not have made it to the loudest headlines but did mark important phases in India's political, economic and social transformation from 1975 to 2009.

To India, 1975 will always stand for the imposition of the Emergency, an act that historian Sunil Khilnani describes as "an assault on India's constitutional identity". But it was also a year which will set off very different memories for millions of Indians—the release of a film called *Sholay*. If 1999 marked the Kargil War, that year ended with the unfortunate hijacking of Indian Airlines IC-814 which exposed India as a soft state. Everyone remembers that 1991 marked economic liberalisation, but not many would remember that in that year, India's aviation also opened its doors to the private sector, a decision whose eventual benefits have been felt only recently with low-cost airline operations.

Our cover story this week is called 'The Secret History' which focuses on the smaller events that had a big impact. Khilnani's essay on the changes in Indian democracy between 1975 and 2009 opens the cover package. Our correspondents from across the country, beat specialists and experts then track various routes back in these times to highlight the quieter events and give us their take on what really happened, why it happened and what it all meant.

It has been said, "History never looks like history when you are living through it. It always looks confusing and messy." That is true. Well, we hope the INDIA TODAY 34th anniversary issue will bring clarity and perspective to our readers in what is a fascinating journey through India's very interesting times.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR DECEMBER
2008 COVER